Kidnap Poem and Poem for Aretha

By Nikki Giovanni

Kidnap Poem

ever been kidnapped

by a poet

if i were a poet

i'd kidnap you

put you in my phrases

and meter you to jones beach

or maybe coney island

or maybe just to my house

lyric you in lilacs

dash you in the rain

alliterate the beach

to complement my see

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play the lyre for you

ode you with my love song

anything to win you

wrap you in the red Black green

show you off to mama

yeah if i were

a poet i'd kid

nap you

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INTRODUCTION

African-American women have contributed to music significantly over the last several decades. It is also significant to note that many African-American musicians succeeded at a time when blacks were still the recipients of discrimination in the United States.

An American songwriter, singer and pianist, Aretha Franklin (aka the Queen of Soul) is regarded at least by Rolling Stone magazine to be the greatest singer who ever lived. She became famous in the late 1960s with the hit song "Respect." In Poem for Aretha, Nikki Giovanni pays her tribute and "respect" to this amazing woman and the other black musicians who forged new ground in the music industry. After all . . . it was Johann Paul Richter who said . . . "Music is the poetry of the air"

Poem for Aretha

Cause nobody deals with Aretha—a mother with four
children— having to hit the road
they always say "after she comes
home" but nobody ever says what it's like
to get on a plane for a three week tour
the elation of the first couple of audiences the good
feeling of exchange the running on the high
you get from singing good
and loud and long telling the world
what's on your mind.

then comes the eighth show on the sixth day the
beginning
to smell like the plane or bus the if-you-forget-your-
toothbrush
in-one-spot-you-can't-brush-until-the-second-show
the strangers
pulling at you cause they love you but you having no love
to give back
the singing the same songs night after night day after

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day
and if you read the gossip columns the rumors that your
husband
is only after your fame
the wondering if your children will be glad to see you and
maybe
the not caring if they are scheming to get out
of just one show and go just one place where some doe-
doe-dupaduke
won't say "just sing one song, please"

mobody mentions how it feels to become a freak
because you have talent and how
no one gives a damn how you feel
but only cares that Aretha Franklin is here like maybe
that'll stop:
chickens from frying
eggs from being laid
crackers from hating

and if you say you're lonely or tired how they always

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just say "oh come off it" or "did you see
how they loved you did you see huh did you?"
which most likely has nothing to do with you anyway
and i'm not saying Aretha shouldn't have talent and i'm
certainly
not saying she should quit
singing but as much as i love her i'd vote "yes" to her
doing four concerts a year and staying home or doing
whatever
she wants and making records cause it's a shame
the way we're killing her.
we eat up artists like there's going to be a famine at the
end
of those three minutes when there are in fact an
abundance
of talents just waiting let's put some
of the giants away for a while and deal with them like
they have
a life to lead

Aretha doesn't have to relive billie holiday's life doesn't

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have
to relive dinah washington's death but who will
stop the pattern?

she's more important than her music—if they must be
separated—
and they should be separated when she has to pass out
before
anyone recognizes she needs
a rest and i say i need
aretha's music
she is undoubtedly the one who put everyone on
notice.
She revived johnny ace and remembered lil green
Aretha sings
"i say a little prayer" and dionne doesn't
want to hear it anymore
aretha sings "money won't change you"
but james can't sing "respect" the advent
of aretha pulled ray charles from marlboro country
and back into

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the blues made nancy wilson
try one more time forced
dionne to make a choice (she opted for the movies)
and diana ross had to get an afro wig pushed every
Black singer into his Blackness and negro entertainers
into negroness you couldn't jive
when she said "you make me/feel" the blazers
had to reply "gotta let a man be/a man"
aretha said "when my soul was in the lost and found/you
came
along to claim it" and joplin said "maybe"
there has been no musician whom her very presence
hasn't
affected when humphrey wanted her to campaign she
said
"woeman's only hueman"
and he pressured james brown
they removed otis cause the combination was too strong
the impressions had to say "lord have mercy/we're
moving on up"
the Black songs started coming from the singers on

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stage and the dancers
in the streets
aretha was the riot was the leader if she had said "come
let's do it" it would have been done
temptations say why don't we think about it
think about it
think about it

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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